

The Inner Game & Improved Self-Talk

Myth Busting

- Mindfulness and meditation are long and boring practices which have to take up a lot of time and effort. As it happens, this is completely untrue. Mindfulness is a way of living and engaging with the world around us. Instead of being continuously engaged in thoughts of the past and future we look to turn our focus and attention to the inner and outer world in the present moment.
- My thoughts are all real. This is simply not true. Sometimes we can call ourselves terrible things like “you’re a loser” but we can actually challenge this thought by forcing ourselves to define a loser and to think of a time when we did something correctly.
- High performers have a higher level of positive and resilient thinking which I will never be able to tap into. Not true! We can retrain our minds how to frame scenarios and look at them more as opportunities to grow than problems.

Self-Talk

- If you talk to yourself in a way that you would never allow yourself to talk to a friend then you need to work on your self-talk. Negative self-talk will have an effect on how we look, feel and behave so it is worth investing some time in getting our self-talk right.
- Go through the distorted types of thinking in the module and use them to identify future negative thinking patterns. Then think about how could I talk back to this thought in a more optimal way.
- A quick example is somebody who always tells themselves that “I should lose weight” when it may benefit their stress and motivation levels by changing it to “I could lose weight”. The latter statement works more from a point of self-determination instead of guilt and obligation.

Framing

- Top performers all have ways to work through adversity and negative thought patterns which could hold them back from delivering their best. Performance Treanor interviewees adapted the following mindsets:

Musician, Eimear McGeown told negative thoughts to go away and come back later. She would do this in the lead up to big performances.

One of the best gaelic footballers of all time, Pat Spillane used negative media stories about him to say to himself, “I am going to go out and prove them wrong”. On the other hand, if they said he was the best in Ireland then he would say, “I am going to go out and prove them right”. This is an example of win-win thinking.
- It has been shown that 75% of job successes are predicted by optimism levels, social support and an ability to frame stress as a challenge and not a threat.

